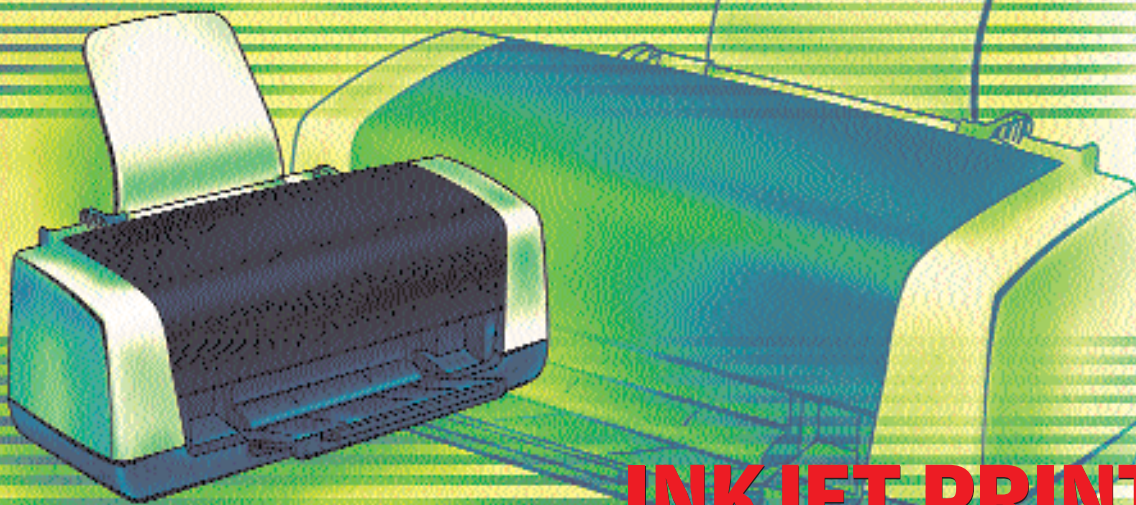




INKJET PRINTERS

The newer inkjet printers we've tested have surprised us with their compact sizes, feature-rich printing and affordable prices, which wasn't the case until even a year ago. This hints that the printer market is becoming even more competitive—the big players are waging price wars, while still maintaining quality control.

Questions to ask the dealer

Can I print a test page?

Never assume the quality of a printer without testing it. Stats on paper might not reflect true values. Carry a document that you made yourself and demand a test page print. The document should contain simple text of different font sizes, graphs, and a quarter-page colour

photograph. Trust your eyes—what you see here is what you're going to get.

What about the cartridges?

It is crucial that you have a complete picture of the costs you are going to incur. It's the running cost of a printer that matters, and you need to find out how long a cartridge lasts and how much a new one is going to cost. Remember, entry-level printers can actually be cheaper than the cartridges themselves.

What else do I get?

Confirm the accessories that you will get along with your printer; these may include printer cables, a power cord and even some photo paper. Make sure to check the package contents mentioned on the box before you leave the store.

What about warranty and service?

Don't forget these details—such peripherals often need expert attention.

Usage Tips

❑ Do not print on an empty cartridge—this may damage the printer. The ink in the cartridge also acts as a coolant for the heat sink of the print head.



Points To Ponder

When do I choose an inkjet printer?

Inkjet printers are typically suited for home users and small offices. They are cheaper and have enough features bundled for home users, such as PictBridge support to print photos directly from a camera. Some printers also include memory card support and an LCD display, which allows the printer to work without connecting it to a PC.

What options do I have?

inkjets may be classified as general purpose and photo inkjet printers. Do not confuse photo inkjets with photo printers: the latter are designed specifically for printing 4 x 6 (or smaller) photo-quality prints.

What specs should I look for?

Print quality can be inferred from the resolution, which is given in dots per inch. If a printer can print more dots per inch, it will print a sharper picture. But with the precision and increase in resolution, the speed will be compromised. If your purpose is to print photos, then you should consider a good-quality inkjet printer with a high resolution, even if it is more expensive and

slower than other printers. The ideal resolution for a photo printer is between 1200 x 1200 and 4800 x 1200 dpi.

The speed of printing will be a factor for those who aren't bothered about the quality of the printer output. The manufacturer will have listed ppm (pages per minute) figures in their specification sheet, but remember that real-world performance is always a little lower. A printer with a resolution of 600 x 600 to 1200 x 1200 dpi and 20 pages per minute for a draft printout is a decent buy.

If your printer is shared on a network and you expect the printer to be accessed by many users at once, then a printer that has more memory and a good processor is preferable. For a single user, a processor-based printer isn't an important criterion.

Paper can be fed from the top or from the bottom of the printer. It is up on the user to decide what suits him, but a bottom (horizontal tray) feed is generally preferred, since papers can be left in the tray without worrying about paper folds.

❑ You can refill an ink cartridge, but this is not advisable. Stick to manufacturer-produced cartridges as far as possible. Some manufacturers also have provisions to collect used cartridges for recycling. Also, visit the manufacturer's Web site to find out how to identify original cartridges, as you may get ripped off by dealers selling refilled and repackaged duplicates. This happens a lot in India—so beware!

❑ Do not keep your printer idle for too long (over two to three months)—the ink may dry up inside the cartridge!

❑ Some printer drivers can automatically optimise a printout by detecting the content type for printing. This helps save ink—use it!

❑ Windows XP users can use the print wizard to print pictures—the wizard lets you choose different layouts and album sizes (such as 4 x 6) with an embedded preview window.

❑ You can print images onto iron-on-transfer sheets and then iron them on to any clothing. Make sure you print in Best mode when doing this. ■